

Fixing Strava's Leaderboard Problem

A product sense case study: why a leaderboard built to motivate demotivates almost everyone on it

The insight

A Strava Segment leaderboard with 100,000 athletes on it has room for about 100 people to realistically see themselves as contenders.

99,900

of every 100,000 athletes on a global leaderboard

see a rank that only tells them how far they are from mattering, every single time they check.

This isn't a guess.

It's a named idea in behavioral science: social comparison theory. People are motivated by comparing themselves to similar others, not to distant elites.

A mid-pack runner isn't demoralized by an elite athlete. They're demoralized by a system that makes that comparison the primary feedback they get.

Why this is a business problem, not a UX nitpick

Full segment leaderboards sit behind Strava's paid subscription.

The feature Strava charges for is the same feature that, for almost everyone who encounters it, produces a number that makes them want to open the app less.

The paywalled hook actively discourages the exact segment of users least likely to already be hooked.

150M+ athletes globally

Segments are a premium feature

Premium priced at \$79.99/year

What I'd actually build

Not a new feature. A new default view of the same data: a peer-tier leaderboard, shown first.

BEFORE

Rank 8,412 of 100,000

on this Segment

Tells a mid-pack runner exactly one thing: how far they are from the people who were never going to be their real competition.

AFTER

3rd among runners near your pace

40 seconds off 1st in that group

The reference group is people you could plausibly beat, or recently lost to by a small margin. Global rank still exists, one tap away.

The trade-off worth naming out loud

A peer-tier view is easier to feel good in than a global one deserves.

Someone could feel like a top performer in an artificially narrow group. I'd treat that as an accepted cost, deliberately, not an oversight.

The entire point is making the comparison feel earned and close. A comparison that's technically softer but emotionally real drives more return visits than one that's technically rigorous and demotivating.

I would say this directly to a team, not hide it in a pitch: this trades comparison rigor for retention, and I think that's the right trade for this feature.

What I'd measure before calling it a win

NORTH STAR

Week-over-week return rate

Among users whose most recent segment effort placed them in the bottom half of a global leaderboard, exactly the population being lost today.

COUNTER-METRIC

Top 1% engagement

Watch users already served well by the global view. Winning the new mechanic can't come at the cost of losing the old one's power users.

THE TEST

Randomized default, 30 days

Half of users default to peer-tier on new segment completions, half keep global. Compare return rate within the bottom-half population specifically.

Notice the mechanism, not just the symptom.

Social comparison theory explained why the leaderboard was quietly working against the users it needed most. Naming the mechanism is what turns a UX complaint into a design decision.